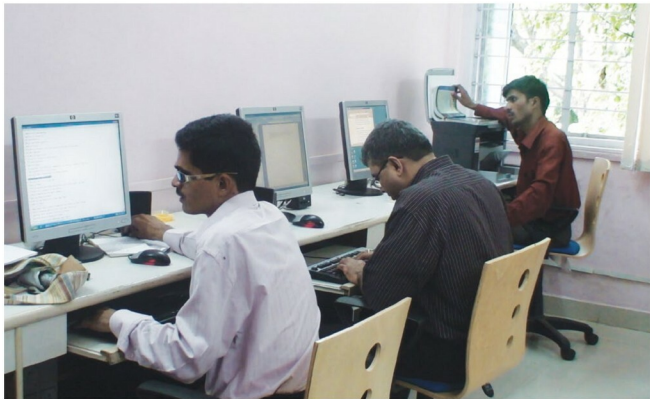


What Does Open Source Offer the Differently Abled?

There is no reason why the differently abled cannot use computers as well as others. Free and open source accessibility tools are the means by which the physically and otherwise challenged can enjoy a complete, wholesome and enriching IT experience. This article looks at a few of these tools.



Life has become so much simpler thanks to information technology. But are the day-to-day activities that you carry out in cyberspace, like checking your mail, surfing the Web, making an online payment, etc, accessible to every single human being on earth, including persons with disabilities (PWD) and the elderly? Surely they have some special requirements. Let's look at the various free and open source tools that will make access to computers for people with special needs smoother and act as an eye-opener to the concept of accessible computing. Developers can make an impact on the lives of people with special needs by their open source contributions.

Persons with disabilities (PWD) are the largest invisible minority of the world. According to United Nations statistics,

15 per cent of the world population (1 billion) is disabled. With the rapid improvements in medicine, the average life span is constantly increasing. The United Nations has declared that in countries where the average life span is more than 70, the elderly spend, on an average, eight years with some sort of disability. These statistics reveal the necessity of making cyberspace accessibility mandatory. IT can bring great benefits into the lives of this group. 'Break barriers, open doors: For an inclusive society and development for all' was the theme at the United Nations during International Day for persons with disabilities, 2013. Breaking barriers and opening doors is equally important in cyberspace—as much as in the physical world.

While some proprietary accessibility software tools for people with special needs do exist, they are expensive. So